

The Monkey's Paw

W. W. Jacobs · 1902

First published: Harper's Monthly, Sep 1902

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Lady_of_the_Barge/The_Monkey's_Paw (revision 15611995), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Monkey's Paw suggest about fate and greed?
- What does The Monkey's Paw suggest about be careful what you wish for?
- What does The Monkey's Paw suggest about grief?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Monkey's Paw	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*fate and greed* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Monkey's Paw

Focus: wishes that defy fate

Content note (death of a son, horror): Sensitive content: Death of a son; horror. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death of a son; horror.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Sergeant-Major Morris brings the Whites a mummified monkey's paw from India, cursed by a fakir to grant three wishes to three men. Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds. The next day their son Herbert is killed in machinery at work, and the company pays two hundred pounds. Mrs. White makes her husband wish Herbert alive. A knocking comes at the door; as she unbolts it, Mr. White uses the last wish, and the road outside is empty.

Background: Published in 1902 in Harper's Monthly; British readers knew India through soldiers like Morris returning from imperial service.

Significance: A classic of the horror tale that leaves its terror offstage; Gale's Short Stories for Students features it.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes death of a son; horror.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are sideboard, dangling, undecided, resounded, coincidence. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues." In this sentence it means: a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Monkey's Paw would have known. Published in 1902 in Harper's Monthly; British readers knew India through soldiers like Morris returning from imperial service. Why does this story matter? A classic of the horror tale that leaves its terror offstage; Gale's Short Stories for Students features it. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for foreshadowing.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "In the brightness of the wintry sun next morning as it streamed over the breakfast table he laughed at his fears." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to wishes that defy fate? I circle "sideboard", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find foreshadowing, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for foreshadowing.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of foreshadowing. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *In the brightness of the wintry sun next morning as it streamed over the breakfast table he laughed at his fears. There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Foreshadowing, Symbolism, Tone / mood: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Monkey's Paw develops the idea of wishes that defy fate. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to fate and greed? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about wishes that defy fate, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how foreshadowing shapes wishes that defy fate. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
sideboard (noun)	a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top	*There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dangling (verb)	hang freely	*He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
undecided (adjective)	not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought	*She was watching the mysterious movements of a man outside, who, peering in an undecided fashion at the house, appeared to be trying to make up his mind to enter.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
resounded (verb)	ring or echo with sound	*A loud knock resounded through the house.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
coincidence (noun)	an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental	*"Morris said the things happened so naturally," said his father, "that you might if you so wished attribute it to coincidence."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
introducing (verb)	presenting (someone) to another person	*"Sergeant-Major Morris," he said, introducing him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
stumbling (verb)	walk unsteadily	*She came stumbling across the room toward him. "I want it," she said, quietly. "You've not destroyed it?"*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pitched (verb)	settled on; chose	*There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong?
2. Where does foreshadowing appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with fate and greed?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who brings the paw? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Sergeant-Major Morris
2. What did the fakir want the paw to show? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: That fate rules people's lives
3. What is the first wish? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Two hundred pounds
4. How does the money arrive? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: As compensation for Herbert's death
5. What is the third wish implied to be? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: That the thing at the door go away
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Monkey's Paw" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Sergeant-Major Morris brings the Whites a mummified monkey's paw from India, cursed by a fakir to grant three wishes to three men. Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds. The next day their son Herbert is killed in machinery at work, and the company pays two hundred pounds. Mrs. White makes her husband wish Herbert alive. A knocking comes at the door; as she unbolts it, Mr. White uses the last…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Monkey's Paw"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Monkey's Paw" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief…" What does "sideboard" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: sideboard: a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top.
10. Reread: "He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire." What does "dangling" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: dangling: hang freely.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Monkey's Paw” suggest about wishes that defy fate? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A classic of the horror tale that leaves its terror offstage; Gale's Short Stories for Students features it.
2. Find one example of foreshadowing in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about wishes that defy fate? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins “In the brightness of the wintry sun next morning as it streamed over the breakfast table he laughed at his fears.”, why might Jacobs have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Monkey's Paw”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Sergeant-Major Morris brings the Whites a mummified monkey's paw from India, cursed by a fakir to grant three wishes to three men. Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds. The next day their son Herbert is killed in machinery at work, and the company pays two hundred pounds. Mrs. White makes her…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Monkey's Paw” set up that the rest of The Monkey's Paw will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does tone / mood appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with fate and greed? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling.
10. Background: Published in 1902 in Harper's Monthly; British readers knew India through soldiers like Morris returning from imperial service. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A classic of the horror tale that leaves its terror offstage; Gale's Short Stories for Students features it.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Monkey's Paw" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about wishes that defy fate? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Monkey's Paw": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to be careful what you wish for: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Jacobs need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the foreshadowing in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Monkey's Paw" treats wishes that defy fate with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Monkey's Paw see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve fate and greed? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about wishes that defy fate? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask W. W. Jacobs about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Foreshadowing:** look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Tone / mood**: word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling

Chapter quiz

1. Who brings the paw?

   A. A fakir

   B. Herbert

   C. Sergeant-Major Morris

   D. The company man

2. What did the fakir want the paw to show?

   A. That fate rules people's lives

B. That wishes are free

C. That India is rich

D. That magic is good

3. What is the first wish?

A. Two hundred pounds

B. A new house

C. Long life

D. Herbert's return

4. How does the money arrive?

A. As a lottery prize

B. As compensation for Herbert's death

C. In a letter from Morris

D. As an inheritance

5. What is the third wish implied to be?

A. That the thing at the door go away

B. For more money

C. For Herbert's happiness

D. To die

6. In the line “There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.”, what does “sideboard” most nearly mean?

A. hang freely

B. ring or echo with sound

C. not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought

D. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top

7. In the line “He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire.”, what does “dangling” most nearly mean?

A. ring or echo with sound

B. not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought

C. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top

D. hang freely

Answer key: 1. C (Sergeant-Major Morris); 2. A (That fate rules people's lives); 3. A (Two hundred pounds); 4. B (As compensation for Herbert's death); 5. A (That the thing at the door go away); 6. D (a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top); 7. D (hang freely)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Monkey's Paw,” how does Jacobs show wishes that defy fate? Write a paragraph

that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the foreshadowing you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.W.1): In The Monkey's Paw, how does Jacobs develop the idea of wishes that defy fate? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the foreshadowing in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Monkey's Paw develops the idea of wishes that defy fate. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Monkey's Paw (where it begins, turns and ends) and its foreshadowing shape the reader's understanding of wishes that defy fate. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Monkey's Paw suggests about wishes that defy fate. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's foreshadowing and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how W. W. Jacobs uses foreshadowing in The Monkey's Paw to complicate the reader's understanding of wishes that defy fate. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Monkey's Paw within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of wishes that defy fate responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Monkey's Paw alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of wishes that defy fate follows or bends those conventions, using the foreshadowing as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Monkey's Paw and its treatment of wishes that defy fate. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's foreshadowing and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Monkey's Paw as evidence for a larger claim about wishes that defy fate in The Monkey's Paw. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Monkey's Paw as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of wishes that defy fate. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Monkey's Paw.

SAT-style questions

1. *She was watching the mysterious movements of a man outside, who, peering in an undecided fashion at the house, appeared to be trying to make up his mind to enter.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “undecided” most nearly mean?

   A. walk unsteadily

   B. presenting (someone) to another person

   C. settled on; chose

   D. not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought

2. *In the brightness of the wintry sun next morning as it streamed over the breakfast table he laughed at his fears. There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Monkey's Paw”?

   A. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

   B. A family and a house collapsing together

   C. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

   D. Wishes that defy fate

SAT key: 1. D (not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought); 2. D (Wishes that defy fate)

Whole-book test

The Monkey's Paw: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Who brings the paw?
   A. A fakir
   B. Herbert
   C. Sergeant-Major Morris
   D. The company man
2. What did the fakir want the paw to show?
   A. That fate rules people's lives
   B. That wishes are free
   C. That India is rich
   D. That magic is good
3. What is the first wish?
   A. Two hundred pounds
   B. A new house
   C. Long life
   D. Herbert's return
4. How does the money arrive?
   A. As a lottery prize
   B. As compensation for Herbert's death
   C. In a letter from Morris
   D. As an inheritance
5. What is the third wish implied to be?
   A. That the thing at the door go away
   B. For more money
   C. For Herbert's happiness
   D. To die
6. In the line “There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.”, what does “sideboard” most nearly mean?
   A. hang freely
   B. ring or echo with sound
   C. not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought
   D. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top

7. In the line “He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire.”, what does “dangling” most nearly mean?
   A. ring or echo with sound
   B. not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought
   C. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top
   D. hang freely
8. As used in the story (“There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was”), what does “sideboard” mean?
   A. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top
   B. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental
   C. settled on; chose
   D. ring or echo with sound
9. As used in the story (“He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire.”), what does “dangling” mean?
   A. presenting (someone) to another person
   B. hang freely
   C. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top
   D. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental
10. As used in the story (“She was watching the mysterious movements of a man outside, who, peering in an undecided fashion at the house, appeared to be trying to make”), what does “undecided” mean?
    A. walk unsteadily
    B. hang freely
    C. not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought
    D. presenting (someone) to another person
11. As used in the story (“A loud knock resounded through the house.”), what does “resounded” mean?
    A. settled on; chose
    B. not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought
    C. walk unsteadily
    D. ring or echo with sound
12. As used in the story (“"Morris said the things happened so naturally," said his father, "that you might if you so wished attribute it to coincidence."”), what does “coincidence” mean?
    A. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental
    B. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top
    C. ring or echo with sound
    D. settled on; chose

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how fate and greed develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how be careful what you wish for develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how grief develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (fate and greed, be careful what you wish for, grief) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (Sergeant-Major Morris); 2. A (That fate rules people's lives); 3. A (Two hundred pounds); 4. B (As compensation for Herbert's death); 5. A (That the thing at the door go away); 6. D (a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top); 7. D (hang freely); 8. A (a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top); 9. B (hang freely); 10. C (not brought to a conclusion; subject to further thought); 11. D (ring or echo with sound); 12. A (an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental)

Essay assignments

Essay: Fate and greed

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Monkey's Paw teaches about fate and greed. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how W. W. Jacobs develops fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how W. W. Jacobs develops fate and greed across The Monkey's Paw. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Monkey's Paw (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of fate and greed. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how W. W. Jacobs's choices in The Monkey's Paw (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of fate and greed, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Monkey's Paw's treatment of fate and greed in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw. Name your critical method,

apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Be careful what you wish for

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Monkey's Paw teaches about be careful what you wish for. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how W. W. Jacobs develops be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how W. W. Jacobs develops be careful what you wish for across The Monkey's Paw. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Monkey's Paw (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of be careful what you wish for. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how W. W. Jacobs's choices in The Monkey's Paw (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of be careful what you wish for, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Monkey's Paw's treatment of be careful what you wish for in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Grief

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Monkey's Paw teaches about grief. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how W. W. Jacobs develops grief in The Monkey's Paw. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how W. W. Jacobs develops grief across The Monkey's Paw. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Monkey's Paw (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of grief. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of grief in The Monkey's Paw. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how W. W. Jacobs's choices in The Monkey's Paw (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of grief, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Monkey's Paw's treatment of grief in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on grief in The Monkey's Paw that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on grief in The Monkey's Paw. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about grief in The Monkey's Paw, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on grief in The Monkey's Paw, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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